



VertiGO!!!

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 707 May 2008 PO BOX 1 6 2 8 W E L L I N G T O N

Club nights are at Turnbull House, on the first unimpeded Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings and talks start at 8.00 pm with club business and tea and coffee afterwards. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher public bar at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up.



Aconcagua, December 2007 - Stuart Clark



Section Night 5 May 2008

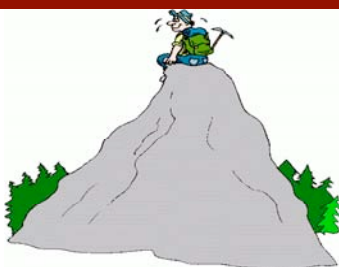
Government sponsored climbing: Craig Jefferies

Craig will talk about two Sport and Recreation New Zealand (SPARC) funded climbing expeditions which occurred in 2008. From the Darran Mountains of Fiordland to the North Face Changabang in India.



Section Trip News

Please send all your fantastic trip reports to newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, so everyone can enjoy your stories.



TRIP REPORTS



A Garden of Eden Crossing

In late January, a mix of members from Wellington and other sections, as well as the odd lapsed member, converged on the Whataroa Hotel for the start of a Garden of Eden trip; much to the amusement of the locals as there were weather warnings out with the tail end of a tropical cyclone approaching. That didn't deter us though, as we were a bunch of hardy well weathered bods (ages ranging from about 55 to at least 65 years). Due to our mature years however we had opted to shorten the trip from a usual 12 day West Coast version G of E trip (starting up the Wanganui) to a 10 day one by making use of the chopper to get us to the edge of the Adams Wilderness on the Lambert Tops, thus cutting out two days hard work. Once in by chopper we headed higher, set up camp and weathered out the rain for two days. Plenty of flood control work was undertaken, along with much sudoku played.

After the rain, it was in via the standard route of crossing into the head of Aciphylla Ck then across into the Lambert catchment before sidling under the NE slopes of Lambert, then across Satan Col and the Garden of Allah to Adams Col. Having last been in the GoE back in the early 80s it was interesting to see changes. The area where we had snow-caved near Adams Col on

those earlier trips was un-snowcavable, now being gentle slopes of ice rather than steeper slopes of deep snow. The snow depression adjacent to Icefall Lookout was now a considerably deeper, steeper ice and rock hole; and the eastern slopes of Mt Farrar were now heavily crevassed. Whether these were just a result of this summer seasons snow conditions or due to long term changes only the experts can tell us. However travel on the extensive snow fields was otherwise straightforward as the slots were tight and visible, so we only occasionally roped up for glacier travel.

We didn't do any significant climbing but relaxed at our comfortable camp near Adams Col, investigating the G of E from Baker Peak in the East to near Mt Barlow in the West. We exited down Adverse Creek into the Perth where we developed an excellent two tent campsite on the TL above the crossing point of the upper Perth. Other parties had camped on the gravel right at the water edge; an interesting to say the least place to spend the night!

The harder days of the trip were the last two days; the long slog down the Perth to Scone Hut, with plenty of wading, pack lowering and some bush bashing all on the TL. Nobody had choppered in any spare kayaks for us to attack the Grade 5 waters in this part of the Perth. (This section is popular with expert kayakers.) The last day was just a standard slog out to the road and the instant hitching of a ride back to the Whataroa pub.

The Garden of Eden; an amazing place to get to, and a thoroughly recommended 10 or 12 day trip from the West Coast.

The six of us were Barry Scott, Alasdair Noble, Terry Crippen (Palmerston North); Pat Holland (Nelson); Conway Powell, Rod MacLeod (Dunedin).

Terry Crippen



Spending Easter in the Garden

Easter Friday saw Richard Davies, Hannah McGregor and Ben Clark battling a typically fresh westerly breeze up the Clyde. Rain (and the thought of sharing McCoy with Thar hunters) forced an early stop at Watchdog hut, and we didn't begin again until Saturday afternoon when the rain stopped. Saturday night was spent in the clag at the confluence of the Agnes and the Frances. Sunday was a great day and we made the long slog up the Wee McGregor to Perth Col, with plenty of slots en route. Many other slots were negotiated on the top of the Perth glacier, but the good campsites at Adams Col were safely reached. The plateau itself was surprisingly slow travel and quite cut up in places (needless to say quite different from my previous visit there in Feb 2001) but was negotiable to the head of Adverse Creek which we descended into and camped in lower down. From there we bounced down the boulders of the Perth for a night at Scone hut. After a night in Bettison stream, bad weather prevented us sneaking across Dennistoun Pass which meant a rather longer trek back to the car via the now flooded Perth and some lucky hitch hiking from Whataroa. Another great Transalpine wander.

Richard Davies



Summer Rock 2008

It's a Tuesday night in early February and the first session of the Summer Rock course at Ferg's. There are 12 students – Melody, Clare, Catherine, Ralf, Neil, Dawn, Shichang, Gwen, Sarah, Kate, Lou and me (Gill) – most of whom have done a little climbing before. There is a sense of nervous anticipation as we sit around putting on shoes and harnesses and listening to Scott introduce the course and the instructors.

Over the course of the next few Tuesday nights, we learn to climb, belay, abseil, lead climb and tie anchors. At first we spend a bit of time each session on the bouldering wall learning how to use holds for our hands and feet, practising in-lines and diagonals, and then practising on the slab, in my case, using any hold I can reach. Helpful advice comes from the floor: “there is a good hold for your right foot up by your elbow. Can you get your foot there, then get your weight over it and stand up”.

We spend a couple of Tuesdays focusing on abseiling with Blair. He runs through safety issues and how to set up for abseiling with three of us at a time, then each in turn we attach ourselves to the rope, talk through our set up to Blair and the other students and one by one stand up on the ledge, undo our safety sling and step backwards to descend rather slowly to the ground. Then we do it again, and again.

Later in the course, we learn about knots and anchors, and to lead climb out the back at Ferg's. Clare belays when it is my turn to try lead climbing. We have chosen a climb which is in a corner and has a large fat bulge of an overhang two thirds of the way up. It's not too difficult at first and I manage to climb and clip the rope into the first three quickdraws relatively easily, then I come to the overhang. I have one foot wedged against a small protrusion on the side wall and the other pushing into a round hold just above the overhang on the main wall. I'm not happy with where my hands are; my right hand is losing its grip on the hold, so I try to adjust it, so that I can use my other hand to clip the rope I have pulled up with me. Before I manage that my left hand starts to slip. Somehow I do a backward flip and suddenly I am face down in sky diving style not very far above Clare's startled face. The force of my fall has pulled her right off the ground.

Trip to Wharepapa South

Friday night after work the Summer Rock students and instructors meet at Wellington railway station. We are waiting for Blair and Scott to arrive in hired vans to take us to Wharepapa South, somewhere north west of Lake Taupo. This will be our first weekend away.

We pile into the vans; it's a long drive – 6 hours – and we arrive at Bryce's backpackers at 1 am.

Next morning we're to leave Bryce's at 9 am but somehow it's 9.30 before the last instructor and student are winkled out of Bryce's shop. We drive the short distance to Froggatt Edge, park the vans and get ready for the rock.

The instructors set up top ropes on the Slug Wall for warm up climbs. The rock is ignimbrite and pitted with small holes. There is a generous ledge well up the wall, conveniently placed for a rest stop. A couple of climbs and it's after midday already. It's scorching and the climbs are in the sun – we go through a lot of sunblock and water.

After lunch we move down to Bring Your Daughter wall and Retour for some practice lead climbing. I am feeling a little nervous so Scott takes me up to a large boulder to practise lead climbing without me having to worry about falling. It's disconcerting that he only has to walk round the back of the boulder to check my efforts at tying anchors. Encouraged I feel prepared to have a go at a short easy-looking lead climb.

After showers back at Bryce's, we head into Te Awamutu to the Redoubt for dinner. The Redoubt is full to overflowing; people are standing drinking on the street and the bar itself is crammed and noisy. We stay only long enough to eat and then head back to bed.

Sunday morning a number of people are sporting shiny new gear having got up early to make the most of Bryce's shop. We are all in the vans by 9.15 and heading back to Froggatt Edge; this time we start off in Animal Biscuit Valley. Scott has some of us tying anchors at the bottom of Retour, while the others revisit the Slug Wall.

Emily belays me while I practise lead climbing on Retour which has a tricky little chimney-like feature that is rather lacking in holds (at least for the vertically challenged). At the top I attach my safety to one of the bolts and call "safe!" And it feels very safe since there is enough room at the top for me to sit comfortably while I prepare to abseil down.

"Off belay?"

"Off belay." I clip some coils of rope to my harness and untie the rope from the belay loop. I run the end of the rope through the bolts looping it as I pull it through. When I have pulled enough rope through to reach the ground, I throw the loops of rope down.

"Rope!"

The rope now comes up from the ground through the bolts and down to the ground again. I tie my prusik round the double thickness of rope well below the bolts and fasten it to my harness with a karabiner and lock the karabiner, then taking hold of the rope above the prusik I push a loop of rope from each side of the bolts through my belay device and attach all to my safety sling with another karabiner. I lock the karabiner. I lean back to test that this set up will hold me. It does, so I undo my safety from the bolts and stand up with my back to the drop, lean back slowly and start to abseil down.

After lunch I feel sufficiently rested and confident to try something a little harder. This time Catherine belays for me and I attempt Moon Base Alpha as my last climb of the day. It's tricky as it starts at the edge of a shallow cave but somehow I haul myself up and then it's almost vertical. At first there are plenty of holds but as I climb higher and my arms start to ache, it becomes more challenging. Almost at the last little ridge I make the mistake of looking down. Sore arms and vertigo decide me on retreat, despite the urging of those below me.

Catherine, though, still has lots of energy; she climbs the slab to the left of the Moon Boulder (which we misread as Superwitch) before it's time to head home.

Whanganui Bay, Lake Taupo

Another Friday evening departure and drive to Whanganui Bay on the western shore of Lake Taupo. We arrive in the dark and walk from the car park to the camping area carrying our gear and setting up camp by the light of head torches.

Saturday morning after a surprisingly good sleep, Kate and I are last up, but no-one's rushing so there is time for breakfast and espresso – the latter courtesy of Ralf. About 9.30 we head off along the beach to the Whekenui Cliffs.

At the cliffs, groups of three (two learners with an instructor) prepare for different climbs. Shane has picked out a climb with a crack running up it for Gwen and me to warm up on. Then it's a two pitch climb with Shane leading, Gwen next attached to the rope with an alpine butterfly, then me last. As I get to the top of the first pitch I get my head above the trees and can see the spectacular view of the valley and the bay. A short distance away I can see Shichang on Tibia.

We abseil down from the top of the second pitch and decide to try 50 Dean Street – the second part of this is a real challenge for me even with Shane belaying me from the top, but I get there in the end to the relief of both of us. To wrap up the day we climb Surrogate.

It's early evening as we wander back along the beach towards the camp and we can see some figures standing out in the lake. Gwen and I quickly get changed and go in for a swim. By the time we have got out and got dressed, most of the others are sitting around enjoying Scott's delicious stew, and wine or beer, then out comes the chocolate and liquorice.

Next morning we march off to the Plateau to try some different climbs before we have to get back on the road south.

Thanks to all the instructors for a great course and two wonderful weekends – Scott, Blair, Derek, Lou, Siobhan, Callum, Shane, Marcus, Emily and Matt (and to Reuben for his quiet supervision from below).

Gill James



CLASSIFIED



Seeking.....

My name is Steve Bell and I'm trying to find a guy I climbed Mt Cook with in 1985.

His name is Steve Bruce.

I have a couple photos I wanted to send him and reconnect.

If you know Steve Bruce, or know someone that knows him can you please contact the Editor on newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



Transceivers for sale.....

Alpine Guides is selling a limited number of Ortovox F1 and X1 avalanche transceivers. This is part of a process of buying in new units every winter. The units are fully serviceable and have been in recent use.

It is important to note that while these units are in excellent condition you need to constantly check them. We do this even with new units so it is not rocket science. Be quick as last year these sold very quickly.

Ortovox F1: \$180.00 including GST and postage per unit
Ortovox X1 Digital: \$250.00 including GST and postage per unit.

Contact:

Alpine Guides
P O Box 20
Mount Cook
03 435 1834
mtcook@alpineguides.co.nz
www.alpineguides.co.nz



For Sale.....

Old style wooden handled ice axes (2). Straight adzes, 85cm hickory shafts, stamped with "Cornelius, Whitehouse and sons Ltd, England, 1944", used and antique looking but generally good condition. Suit ornamental use only. \$200 each + postage (\$11-30 to Nth Island). The North Otago Section are selling these and replacing them with modern axes for hiring out. Email for photos.

Contact Nick Shearer, shearer@es.co.nz



For Sale.....

1 Black Diamond Ladies Technical Harness (Primrose) \$110
1 Black Diamond ATC Belay Device \$45
Excellent condition, used only twice, negotiable.

1 Black Diamond Quick Draw
1 Black Diamond RockLock Twistgate
1 HB Clipper D shape
1 Austri Alpine Karabiner
Never used, negotiable.

All original literature and tags etc accompany the gear.

Please phone Sally on 09 480 5545 or 027 627 7613.



Give a new life to your old climbing ropes

At Raphael House Rudolf Steiner School, the children do a lot of skipping for co-ordination and fitness, and the best ropes are heavy and flexible – just like an old 9 or 11 mm kern mantle rope. So if you have an old worn out rope that would like a new life as skipping ropes, please phone Catharina on 589 0556 to organise collection.



CLUB NOTICES



Home of Mountaineering Display

The NZAC National Office is currently working on a display idea in conjunction with the Canterbury Museum. We are hoping to have items on show in the Reference Library that are changed every six months. This notice is to ask members to send us their ideas on what they would like to see displayed. Given that planning would need to be made well in advance, please include any upcoming anniversaries that you may know of, even if they are years away, e.g. it could be celebrating a first ascent – 100 years since: Freda du Faur 1st women to climb Mt Cook 1913, 1st ascent of Mt Aspiring 1909, or about topics – rock climbing, women climbing, equipment used 100 years ago, Section anniversaries, famous climbers, etc. The more ideas I receive, the more there will be to work with. Also, for those that cannot make it to see a display in person, an article and photograph of the display can be placed on the website.

Please send your suggestions as soon as possible to Margaret at the National Office, PO Box 786, ChCh 8140, or email Margaret (at) alpineclub.org.nz so that they can be organised in time for the draft proposal.



Special Thanks – Ruapehu Hut Workers

The National Office would like to extend a special thank you to the people below who gave their time to assist with the Ruapehu working party on the weekend of 14-16 March. Led by Richard Knott, the party put in a mammoth painting effort, installed a new kitchen bench top and even got some of those finicky inside jobs completed. All in the nick of time before the winter weather hits. With such high demands on people's time these days, we wanted to make sure that all those involved realised how grateful we are for all their hard work.

Thanks go to: Richard Knott (CNI), Brad White, Kate Williman, Igor and Natalia Drecki, Ken and Joe Sparks, John Salisbury, Tony and Tess Parlane and Gareth Lathey (AK), Terry Crippen, Neil Hay and Mark Yeo (WN), plus Sarah Johnson (visitor from Canada)



Rural Delivery Addresses

To retain our bulk mail discounts with NZ Post, we have to have 85% accuracy of members' addresses. Every part of the address lines have to be correct and recognised on NZ Post's "Postcode Finder" to make it through the assessment programme. We have over 340 rural delivery addresses many we either have no number for, or they don't have one. They may also be Rapid, or fire numbers, c/- RD addresses, or farm names with no number. Going through these has shown that many we have on record, are not recognised by NZ Post. It would be appreciated if any member with a RD address, or having mail directed C/- a RD address and who don't know

their street number and name, please contact their local council. They will be able to tell you what your officially recognised number is and it would be greatly appreciated if you could pass this on to me as soon as possible, please. If you are using a RD as a C/- address, I will also need to know the registered RD holders name as well. You are welcome to check what is on our database, if you are not sure.

Thank you

Margaret@alpineclub.org.nz (NZAC, PO Box 786, Christchurch Mail Centre 8140)



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Alpine Club Members with card can climb anytime for \$8.
Monday nights show your members card and climb for \$5.



CLUB TRIPS

Wellington Section Trips

Trips are a key part of the section, so if anyone has an idea about a trip, no matter how vague, send an email to trips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz).

Trips can be of any length, any level of difficulty, and any size. Simply email us, or approach us at the monthly meeting, and we can help you get going.

Trips for the Calendar so far...

24-28Apr08 – Mt Murchison (2408m) - ANZAC weekend trip – Leader = Don French

Highest peak in Arthur's Pass NP. Route in will be up the Waimakariri River via Carrington Hut, then the White River to arrive at Barkers Hut at the base of the White Glacier. Ideal for those who have recently completed the AIC. Contact Don at 027 445 2980 or 06 377 7117 or by email at df@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz.



Murchison (on left) and the White Glacier

9-11May08 – Kawakawa Bay, Taupo – Leader = James Wright

Take a trip to the newly developed crags of nearby Kawakawa Bay. Come along for a weekend of trad and sport climbing on some quality rock, against the backdrop of the largest lake in the North Island. Hone up on those rock skills with some full pitch climbs. Enjoy the hot pools nearby when your day is done. Contact James at 232 7748 or by email at james.wright@xtra.co.nz



Whanganui Bay

30May-2Juno8 – Mt Tapuae-o-Uenuku (2880m) – Leader = TBA

Opening alpine snow trip for the winter season! Come climb the second highest peak in NZ outside the Mt Cook area. This was one of Hillary's early climbs back in the 1940's, except instead of doing it in 1 day like Sir Ed did we'll take 3! On Friday night we'll take the ferry and stay near the road end. Saturday will be the trip in up the Hodder River to stay at the Hodder Huts – some 66 crossings! On Sunday we'll attempt a summit via the traditional south ridge. No ropes required. Contact Kevin at 934 0975 or by email at kp@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz.



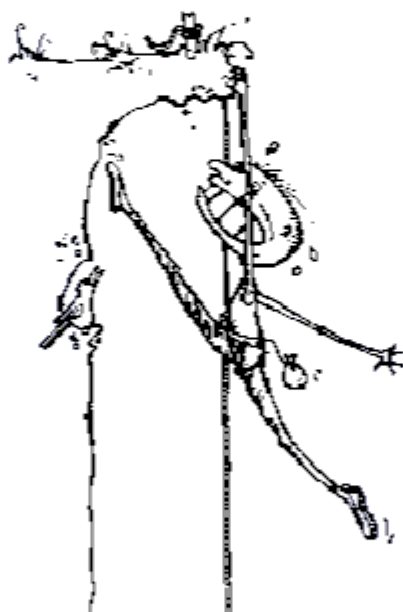
Mt Tapuae-o-Uenuku Summit ridge



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Treasurer	Karen Domaneschi	TREASURER <i>or</i> KD	N/A
National Representative	Jennifer Brown and James Wright	JB2 <i>or</i> JW	N/A
	Garth London and Judy Reid	GL <i>or</i> JR	(04) 479 2984 (Garth)
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National Instruction Rep	Rachael Schmidt	RS	N/A
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Trips	Kevin Patterson	TRIPS <i>or</i> KP	N/A
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* Email address is alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, eg: secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



If undelivered please return to:

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